

SEID 2364 – Assignment 13 Ethical Position Statements Portfolio

Section 1 – Reflection on Ethical Development At the beginning of the semester, my understanding of ethics was relatively simple. I viewed ethics primarily as a matter of personal behavior and individual responsibility. If a person was honest, respectful, and avoided causing harm, I considered that person ethical. While I still believe these qualities are important, this course challenged me to think beyond individual actions and examine how systems, institutions, technologies, and policies influence ethical outcomes. One of the most important lessons I learned was that ethical problems rarely involve a single stakeholder. Through discussions, journal reflections, and assignments, I encountered situations where different groups experienced harms and benefits differently. What appears fair from one perspective may appear unfair from another. This realization changed how I think about decision-making. The Moral Machine exercise had a significant impact on my thinking. Initially, I assumed that there would be a clear moral answer in most scenarios. Instead, I discovered that reasonable people often disagree because they prioritize different values. Some prioritize maximizing lives saved, while others emphasize fairness, dignity, or rights. I generally agreed with many of the majority decisions but also recognized that aggregated preferences do not automatically create moral legitimacy. This experience made me realize that ethical disagreement often comes from different methods of evaluating harm rather than disagreement about facts. Another important development came through harm analysis. Before this course, I mostly thought about harm as physical injury or direct damage. Through assignments and class discussions, I learned that harm can also be psychological, economic, social, reputational, and systemic. A system can function efficiently while still creating significant harms that are difficult to observe immediately. This broader understanding of harm changed the way I evaluate technology and policy decisions. Fairness

became the concept that evolved the most for me. At the start of the semester, I believed fairness meant treating everyone exactly the same. Over time, I learned that fairness can also involve equity, context, vulnerability, and distribution of opportunities. Different frameworks interpret fairness differently, and ethical analysis often requires balancing competing interpretations. Throughout the semester, one belief remained consistent: accountability matters. However, my understanding of accountability expanded. I no longer see responsibility as belonging only to individuals. Organizations, governments, and technology developers also have responsibilities for the systems they create. AI systems may make decisions, but accountability still belongs to the people who design, deploy, and manage those systems. Overall, my ethical perspective developed from a narrow focus on individual behavior into a broader systems-oriented understanding. Ethics is not simply about choosing between right and wrong. It involves evaluating competing harms, competing benefits, stakeholder interests, institutional responsibilities, and long-term societal consequences.

Section 2 – Personal Ethical Position Statement My personal ethical position is that fairness should be the primary principle guiding ethical decision-making. When values conflict, I prioritize fairness and the reduction of preventable harm over efficiency, convenience, or personal gain. I believe that all individuals deserve to be treated with dignity and respect, and that ethical decisions should consider both direct and indirect consequences. Accountability is essential because individuals and institutions must accept responsibility for the outcomes of their actions. Transparency and honesty are important values, but they should be balanced against the possibility of causing unnecessary harm. Ethical action requires thoughtful consideration of stakeholders, context, and long-term effects rather than relying on simple rules alone. This position was shaped by several concepts explored throughout the course. Consequentialist thinking influenced my belief that outcomes matter and that preventable harm should be minimized whenever possible. However, I do not believe outcomes alone determine whether an action is ethical. Deontological ideas influenced my commitment to accountability and respect for individuals. Care ethics influenced my understanding of vulnerability and the importance of considering how decisions affect specific people and communities. My focus on fairness emerged repeatedly throughout the semester. In discussions about healthcare, public policy, and AI systems, I observed that unfair treatment often produces long-term harms that are difficult to reverse. For example, biased decision systems may appear efficient but can systematically disadvantage certain groups. In these situations, fairness becomes more important than maximizing efficiency because unequal treatment can undermine trust and create broader social harms. I also believe ethical reasoning requires humility. Many ethical situations involve uncertainty and competing values. Therefore, ethical decisions should not only seek the best possible outcome but also remain open to revision when new information becomes available. This willingness to reflect and adapt is an important part of ethical responsibility.

Section 3 — Professional Ethical Position Statement

As a future data analyst and data scientist, I believe my primary professional responsibility is to ensure that data-driven systems are fair, accountable, transparent, and respectful of privacy. When organizational objectives conflict with fairness or harm prevention, I believe fairness should take priority. Data professionals have a responsibility to understand the limitations of data, communicate uncertainty honestly, identify potential biases, and consider the broader social consequences of the systems they help create. Ethical responsibility cannot be delegated entirely to algorithms, clients, employers, or automated systems. This position aligns strongly with the ACM Code of Ethics and the IEEE Code of Ethics. Both frameworks emphasize public welfare, avoidance of harm, accountability, and honesty. These principles reinforce the idea that technical success alone is not sufficient. A system can perform well according to technical metrics while still producing harmful or unfair outcomes. The rise of AI systems makes professional ethics increasingly important. Many decisions that were once made by humans are now influenced by algorithms. These systems affect employment, healthcare, education, finance, and public services. Because of this influence, data scientists must think beyond model accuracy and consider fairness, transparency, explainability, and accountability. I believe fairness should be prioritized because unfair systems can create significant societal harms. For example, a highly accurate hiring algorithm may still be problematic if it systematically disadvantages qualified candidates from certain groups. Similarly, predictive systems may produce harmful outcomes if historical data reflects past inequalities. In these situations, technical optimization alone is insufficient. Transparency is also important, but I recognize that complete transparency is not always possible. Some disclosures may compromise privacy or security. Therefore, transparency should be balanced against other ethical responsibilities. Privacy remains essential because individuals should maintain meaningful control over information about themselves. Ultimately, I view professional ethics as an ongoing responsibility rather than a checklist. Ethical practice requires continuous

evaluation of impacts, risks, and stakeholder interests throughout the lifecycle of a system.

Section 4 — Alignment, Tension, and Governmental Authority My personal and professional ethical positions are closely aligned because both prioritize fairness, accountability, and harm reduction. In both contexts, I believe ethical decisions should focus on protecting individuals from preventable harm and ensuring that benefits and burdens are distributed fairly. Despite this alignment, tensions can emerge. Personally, I may value openness and transparency, while professionally I may encounter situations where privacy, security, or confidentiality require limits on disclosure. Similarly, organizational goals may prioritize efficiency or profitability in ways that conflict with my commitment to fairness. Government regulation plays an important role in addressing these tensions. Regulations such as the EU AI Act establish minimum standards and accountability mechanisms for high-risk AI systems. These regulations help protect individuals and create incentives for responsible development. However, legal compliance alone is not enough. History provides many examples of actions that were legal but ethically questionable. For this reason, I believe ethical responsibility extends beyond legal obligations. Professionals should continue evaluating the impacts of their decisions even when regulations are incomplete or absent. Government oversight provides an important foundation, but individual and organizational ethics remain necessary to address emerging challenges.

ection 5 — Position Resilience and Future Capabilities Imagine a future healthcare system in which advanced AI continuously monitors millions of individuals through wearable devices, medical records, genetic information, and behavioral data. The system predicts disease risk, recommends interventions, allocates healthcare resources, and influences insurance pricing. Governments and healthcare providers support the system because it significantly improves efficiency and reduces preventable illness. At first glance, this future appears beneficial. More diseases could be detected early, healthcare resources could be allocated efficiently, and public health outcomes could improve. However, the system also creates significant ethical challenges. My commitment to fairness remains stable in this scenario. I would support the use of advanced technology if it genuinely improves outcomes while treating individuals fairly. However, tensions emerge between fairness, privacy, autonomy, and collective benefit. For example, should insurance providers charge higher premiums to individuals identified as high risk? Should citizens be required to share personal health data if doing so improves public health outcomes? My professional ethical position would require strong safeguards. Transparency, governance, auditing, and human oversight would be necessary to prevent discrimination and misuse. Individuals should have meaningful opportunities to challenge decisions that affect them. Data collection should be limited to legitimate purposes, and systems should be evaluated continuously for bias and unintended consequences. This scenario also highlights the importance of accountability. If an AI system incorrectly identifies individuals as high risk, responsibility cannot simply be assigned to the algorithm. Organizations and professionals involved in the design and deployment of the system must remain accountable. The scenario demonstrates that my ethical positions are relatively resilient because they focus on underlying principles rather than specific technologies. However, it also reveals areas requiring refinement. As technology becomes more powerful, balancing fairness, privacy, autonomy, and collective welfare

becomes increasingly difficult. Future ethical challenges will require adaptation and ongoing reflection rather than rigid adherence to fixed rules.

Section 6 – AI Use Statement Throughout this course, I used AI tools, particularly ChatGPT, as both a productivity tool and a collaborative partner. AI assisted me with brainstorming ideas, organizing information, drafting content, summarizing readings, exploring ethical frameworks, and reviewing written work. In many cases, my interaction with AI involved multiple iterations in which I refined prompts, evaluated responses, and modified outputs to reflect my own understanding. The use of AI influenced my learning by exposing me to alternative perspectives and helping me structure complex arguments. At the same time, I became aware of limitations such as oversimplification, potential inaccuracies, and the risk of becoming overly dependent on automated suggestions. These observations reinforced the importance of critical evaluation and human judgment. BBS Mediation Pathway:

Source: Samuel Adebimpe, personal journal entries, course materials, readings, assignments, and class discussions. Vector: ChatGPT used for brainstorming, ethical analysis, drafting, revision, summarization, and organization of ideas.

Destination: Assignment drafts, reflective writing, ethical analyses, class preparation, and final portfolio submissions. Although AI contributed significantly to my workflow, responsibility for all final decisions, interpretations, and submitted work remained with me. I reviewed outputs, selected content, and ensured that final submissions reflected my own understanding and judgment.

References ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct IEEE
Code of Ethics EU AI Act Course Readings and Discussions Personal
Ethical Journal Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy Moral Machine
Experiment Materials Course Assignments and Case Studies